The Mercury Method: A Comprehensive Manual for Rapid Government Delivery

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Reason Group
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Executive Summary

Mercury is a delivery approach designed specifically for government that guarantees usable outcomes in 13 weeks. Born from necessity after numerous project salvage jobs where hundreds of millions had been spent, Mercury combines high-performance teams, rapid prototyping, customer embedding, and proven principles to deliver value at speed in high-risk government environments.

This manual provides a complete guide to understanding and implementing the Mercury Method, from foundational principles through to practical team structures, rituals, methods, and real-world case studies.

Part 1: Introduction to Mercury

What is Mercury?

Mercury is a service offering that brings the best of what's outside government to the best of what's inside government. Think the passion and energy of a tech startup applied with the quality, assurance, and safety of government.

Mercury: *A way of working that delivers outcomes in a 13-week period through a trans-disciplinary team of data, customer, and technology.*

The Mercury process:

- Generates an outcome in 13 weeks
- Focuses on value and showcases
- Is hyper-agile in responding to changes
- Builds the next step in a chosen solution direction for release

The Origin Story: Born from Necessity

The Mercury Framework was built by Reason after taking on numerous project salvage jobs for many government departments where hundreds of millions had been spent. These projects were often:

- Siloed
- Had spent extensive time writing requirements
- Had little understanding of current data
- Had no input from users or customers

In short 13-week projects, Reason would quickly bring together an understanding of data, architecture, and the customer to deliver fast iterations directly into the hands of users. They would deliver in 13 weeks, with a high-performance unit of trans-disciplinary skills, the value that larger projects had been searching for months to achieve.

After successfully delivering many of these salvage projects, it was proposed that Reason could simply deliver the 13-week project, minus the months and the dollars prior. From here, Mercury was born as a project methodology out of necessity to guarantee outcomes in a Government context.

Why Use Mercury in Government?

The high-risk environment of government requires that we don't waste the resources and time of staff, preventing them from developing in a way that provides outcomes. Often the risk that is missed is:

- Not talking to customers
- Not bringing in a team
- Not building

Often departments become siloed, separating out consultants, architecture, and customers. Mercury builds a sandbox environment that establishes from day one a partnership with the department and the customer, allowing co-design and a constant feedback loop, meaning we can deliver working products.

Key Benefits:

- Extract data rules that unlock investment in legacy systems
- Small trans-disciplinary teams (8-10 people)
- Focus on delivering value in 13 weeks
- End-to-end from whole system, cross-boundaries
- Attack ambiguity with gusto
- Daily iterations
- Customer embedded in the team
- Building from day 1 in a sandbox
- Business to technology together - defining
- Lightspeed feedback loops
- Guaranteed outcome in 13 weeks

Who is Mercury For?

Mercury is designed for:

- **Tech, policy and project teams** that need to rapidly deliver validated outcomes
- **Business-led digital enablement programs** involving business operations, policy and tech
- **Programs of work** that are stuck, facing legacy issues and unclear business cases
- **Government departments** requiring proof of value quickly

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Part 2: The Mercury Manifesto - Core Principles

Mercury is built on five foundational disciplines that define how teams operate:

1. High Performance Teams

Principle: Engage everyone needed from the problem/solution spaces. Data, Technology, Process, and Customer in one team.

Implementation:

- Open access to department data with analysts embedded in the team to ensure we can quantitively understand problems and potential solutions
- Work with a smaller number of customers for the life of the project, putting prototypes into the hands of users
- Understand how they will use the technology, if there are policy changes needed
- Understand complex user requirements through observation and iteration
- Cross-disciplinary collaboration from day one

2. Engage with Purpose

Principle: Understand and maintain mission alignment of our team, our customer, and our customer's purpose/outcomes/objectives.

Implementation:

- Have a clear north star that points the way and is the beacon for course correction throughout
- Build deep engagement between people that improves communication flows and reduces change resistance
- Establish a set of quantifiable success criteria for the project that can be measured against
- Create the clear purpose in a **placemat** (single-page mission alignment document)

3. Listen Faster Than You Deliver

Principle: Build feedback loops that operate faster than your delivery mechanisms.

Implementation:

- Get as much data as early as you can as often as you can
- Help inform the problem hypothesis early with real feedback from the environment, ideally at scale
- The reason you can go fast is that you have a brake (feedback)
- Continuous user testing and validation
- Daily showcases to business and customers

4. Learn Rapidly

Principle: Chunk the journey down and iterate. There are no straight lines.

Implementation:

- Move from data insight, idea, or customer insight to workable prototype as fast as possible
- Deliver multiple prototypes daily in the initial phase
- Course-correct at each waypoint with early showcases
- Use feedback/data to reorient on the north star frequently - stay out of the swamp
- Build a small champion team of 4-5 key business representatives to help validate and ideate ideas
- **Progress over perfection**

5. Attack Ambiguity with Gusto

Principle: Accept that the world is increasingly VUCA (Volatile, Uncertain, Complex, Ambiguous).

Implementation:

- Don't rush to certainty
- Question what people say can't be done
- Prioritize reducing ambiguity in the right order (prove the 'impossible' stuff can be done early)
- Provide certainty for the next step of the journey
- Recognize that the risks you start with may not be the ones you end with

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Part 3: Technical Principles

Mercury projects adhere to six key technical principles:

Cloud First

Use cloud-native services and products to take advantage of modern technological innovations.

Consistent Platform Architecture

Less divergence in architectures and infrastructure within ecosystem.

Reuse

Reuse of existing processes, patterns, and components with minimal changes to existing systems.

Loosely Coupled

Services should be independent, flexible, and event-driven. Services can be developed, adapted, and changed independently of service consumers (Plug & Play).

API First

Design of application keeping in line with use of APIs for interacting with other systems and experience platforms.

Simplicity

Where possible choose simple solutions rather than complex ones. Simple solutions are easy to implement and maintain.

Transparency

Create full visibility of information for consignments as information flows through the ecosystem.

Part 4: Guiding Values

Reason values shape who we are as an organization and are the cornerstones for how we work together:

Empathy: Solve the Right Problem

Time is precious so work smarter, not harder. Prioritize real benefits that matter to people and practice empathy to connect with what matters most. This will guide you to uncover the best levers to pull to make the biggest difference.

Diversity: Learn from Everyone

The world is changing quicker by the day and many great minds can help each other grow. Respect and harness diversity as an essential inspiration in creating the best solutions to tomorrow's problems.

Grit: Stand Against the Tide

When there is a will, there is a way. Dare to think differently. Support those around you to have the grit to dig deep and find a way to overcome any obstacle in the pursuit of delivering meaningful results.

Elegance: Keep it Simple

Less is more. Take on the challenge of creating elegant solutions that cut through complexity in an effortless and easy way. Deliver timeless results by focusing more on what to remove than what to add.

Part 5: The 13-Week Delivery Framework

Mercury is timeboxed to 13 weeks, with clear handover points between phases that allow executives confidence to guarantee an outcome.

Phase 1: Mobilization (Week 1)

Objective: Establish the mission with clear success factors that enable baseline experience to be established.

Activities:

- Establish mission alignment
- Define success criteria
- Set up governance structures
- Identify stakeholders
- Begin building the team

Key Output: Mission placemat with scope, guardrails, and success criteria

Phase 2: Planning (Week 1)

Objective: Build the stakeholders, access the data, elect the leads, champions and build the safe guardrails.

Activities:

- Assemble the full team
- Establish roles and responsibilities
- Set up the sandbox environment
- Define data access requirements
- Create the customer panel
- Build the champion working team

Key Output: Project plan with team structure and guardrails

Phase 3: Discovery (Weeks 2-3)

Objective: Engage the customers and start deep prototypes, working from both ends (data to customer). Establish the rules and start to iterate fast.

Activities:

- Customer research and engagement
- Data exploration and analysis
- Policy and rules analysis
- Initial prototyping (multiple per day)
- Establish feedback loops
- Daily showcases

Key Output: Initial validated prototypes and insights

Phase 4: Delivery (Weeks 4-12)

Objective: Pilot and showcase value fast in the context of an evaluated delivery of work.

The guardrails established in mobilization, the team structure established in planning, and the mission alignment confirmed in discovery ensure successful delivery phases.

Activities:

- Iterative development
- Daily playbacks
- Weekly value showcases
- Continuous user testing
- Champion team validation
- Policy refinement
- Integration testing
- Risk assessment and mitigation

Key Output: Working product in the hands of customers

Phase 5: Approval (Week 13)

Objective: Align on the mission and success criteria to build out the success in documented established understanding to allow the next project to launch.

Activities:

- Final showcase
- Value validation
- Handover documentation
- Lessons learned
- Next steps planning

Key Output: Confirmed value-proven outcome aligned with tech, rules, code, and business requirements

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Part 6: The Mercury Design Process

Mercury follows a non-linear human-centered design approach based on the Double Diamond framework:

Divergent and Convergent Thinking

The central success criteria is mission alignment process, which has periods that are divergent and convergent:

Divergent periods (Discover and Develop) are for:

- Trying many approaches
- Asking "what is the hardest thing to prove?"
- Being open to where the work might take you
- Exercising imagination

Convergent periods (Define and Deliver) are for:

- Focusing on validated solutions
- Creating working solutions

- Showcasing value to ensure mission alignment

Analytical vs Design Approaches

Traditional Analytical Approach:

- Linear process
- Heavy investment early in deep analysis
- Leads to highly informed answer
- Risk: If problem was misunderstood, significant waste

Mercury Design Approach:

- Non-linear process
- Early stages focus on discovering the true problem
- Hold a learning mindset
- Quickly and cheaply test hunches
- Allow the true problem to reveal itself
- Accelerated learning about problem and solution simultaneously

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Part 7: Mercury Team Structure

Mercury teams are high-performance units with defined roles and clear responsibilities.

Core Team Roles

Leadership Roles

Engagement Lead/Project Lead

- Quality assurance
- Risk management
- Plan development
- Governance
- Overall project accountability

Coordinator

- Project administration
- Deliverables scheduling
- Project plan management
- Team meetings cadence

Discipline Leads

Business Consultant

- Research
- Stakeholder engagement
- Business process analysis
- Showcases
- Business documents

Tech Process Expert

- Functional consultant
- System analyst
- Solution design
- Architecture

Business Rules Expert

- Rules engine specialists
- Experience in ML, AI, Java, JSON, and XML

Data Engineer

- AI experience
- Data preparation, collation, design, and architecture
- Integration

Tech Development Expert

- Developers
- Software engineers
- Experience in SAP, Java, Azure, ServiceNow, Salesforce, Oracle
- Automation

Tester

- Functional acceptance

- Performance testing
- End-to-end testing
- Test-driven development

Client Roles

Client Business Representative (1-2 EL1/EL2)

- Engagement with business
- Policy/legislative expertise

Client Subject Matter Experts

- Technical
- Processes
- Governance
- Vendors
- Legal/probity
- Change management

Team Sizes

Mercury offers three standard team configurations:

Small Team (7 FTE)

- **Budget:** $0.99m (GST excl)
- **Best for:** Engagements with clear scope, low risk of schedule slippage, conducive environment
- **Lead:** Senior Manager
- **Contingency:** 10%

Medium Team (10 FTE)

- **Budget:** $1.5m (GST excl)
- **Best for:** Clear scope, wide range of stakeholders, medium risk of schedule slippage, conducive environment
- **Lead:** Senior Manager with Coordinator support
- **Contingency:** 20%
- **Flexibility:** Add additional specialist roles as needed

Large Team (15 FTE)

- **Budget:** $2.5m (GST excl)
- **Best for:** Scope needing clarification, wide range of stakeholders, complex environment, medium risk of schedule slippage
- **Lead:** Principal with Coordinator support
- **Contingency:** 20%
- **Flexibility:** Add additional specialist roles as needed

Discipline Leads Model

Recognizing the range of technical capability in the team, there is a need to organize capability discipline leads. The roles will:

- Own the technical knowledge within the discipline capability
- Drive a sub-team cohort to promote cross-project knowledge transfer
- Be responsible for setting deliverable quality expectations that transcend projects
- Set a training and development plan for each level in the team, including competency assessment
- Manage performance cross-projects (note: performance on project is done by the Project Lead)

Part 8: Mercury Rituals and Ceremonies

Mercury teams follow specific rituals to maintain momentum and alignment:

Daily Rituals

Daily Playback

- **Frequency:** Every day
- **Purpose:** Team synchronization, progress updates, blocker identification
- **Attendees:** Full Mercury team

- **Duration:** 15-30 minutes
- **Format:**
  - What was built yesterday
  - What will be built today
  - What's blocking progress

Daily Showcases (Initial Phase)

- **Frequency:** Multiple times per day during discovery/early delivery
- **Purpose:** Present working prototypes to get immediate feedback
- **Attendees:** Core team + customer panel members
- **Format:** Demo working prototype, gather feedback, iterate

Weekly Rituals

Weekly Value Showcase

- **Frequency:** Every week
- **Purpose:** Demonstrate value to stakeholders, validate direction
- **Attendees:** Full team + champion working team + key stakeholders
- **Duration:** 1-2 hours
- **Format:**
  - Position the need to show early
  - Walkthrough the current state
  - Ask "what else could we do?"
  - Gather feedback and ideas

Champion Working Team Meeting

- **Frequency:** Weekly
- **Purpose:** Brainstorm and develop prototype ideas with 3-5 key business stakeholders
- **Attendees:** 4-5 business representatives + core Mercury team members
- **Format:**
  - Review progress
  - Ideate on problems
  - Validate prototypes
  - Build ideas backlog

Event-Based Ceremonies

Solution Demo

- **Purpose:** Co-design session with customer, tech team, and business where a prototype is used
- **Format:** Hands-on demonstration with working prototype, gather detailed feedback

Hothouse

- **Purpose:** Incubative ideation session
- **Format:** Intensive collaborative workshop to generate breakthrough ideas

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Part 9: Mercury Guardrails and Artifacts

Mercury uses specific practices and artifacts to manage risk and ensure alignment:

The Seven Guardrails

1. CREATE A WORKZONE

We see the greatest risk to any project is an outcome that does not understand the business and customer. We mitigate this by establishing a working understanding with business and customers to mitigate reputation risks or expectations.

2. CREATE A PLACEMAT

We placemat the requirements into a workable single slide that delivers mission alignment whilst keeping open ambiguity on potential solutions.

Placemat Contents:

- Project mission statement

- Scope (what's in, what's out)
- Dependencies
- Success criteria (quantifiable)
- Guardrails and constraints
- Key stakeholders

3. CREATE A SANDBOX

We sandbox the prototypes with obfuscated data to allow it to be as close as possible but built without the need for security.

Sandboxing Benefits:

- Rapid prototyping without security delays
- Data in same form as organizational data
- Safe environment for experimentation
- Ability to involve industry partners

4. CREATE ACTIONABLE PROJECT INSIGHTS

We embed a data champion to find actionable insights within organizational historic data.

5. CREATE A CUSTOMER PANEL

We bring on customers for the life of the project, to see their reactions to prototypes and test integrations and usage.

Customer Panel Approach:

- 40+ willing participants recruited
- Research operations framework
- Consent forms and participant information sheets
- Verbal consent for video recording
- Prism user research library for storage
- Videos and transcripts available across government

6. CREATE A CHAMPION WORKING TEAM

We build champion teams and showcase early and often to increase ideation. The cadence of our prototypes is very high at multiple per day initially. Create Leads of each pillar.

7. CREATE VALUE SHOWCASES DAILY

Regular showcasing is framed as proof of value to demonstrate the prototype and the value it is providing, showing what the pain point is and estimated value for each team member.

Mercury Artifacts

Ideas Backlog

The list of potential prototypes that we can action deliverable-sized projects from.

Placemat

The project mission on a page with the scope, dependencies, and success criteria.

Prototypes

Working demonstrations that can be put in the hands of customers.

Part 10: Mercury Glossary

Mercury: A way of working that delivers outcomes in a 13-week period through a trans-disciplinary team of data, customer, and technology.

Placemat: A process of creating alignment of the mission into a single page that describes the scope, guardrails, and success criteria.

Building for Nobody: Where you are building a product and not showing early because you want to make sure they see the whole product finished. (Anti-pattern)

Library: The recording of requirements in a library that no one will ever look at or use and are untested. (Anti-pattern)

Protobuild: Building a workable prototype that you can put in the hands of customers.

Sandboxing Risk: Building a contained technical environment for prototyping with data that is in the same form as organizational data.

Baker's Dozen: A 13-week delivery cycle.

Handoff Point: Clear defined transitions between project phases.

Solution Demo: A co-design session with a customer, tech team, and business where a prototype is used.

Champions Meeting: A meeting of 3-5 business stakeholders to brainstorm and develop prototype ideas.

Hothouse: Incubative ideation session.

Quicksilver: [Note: Mercury, the element, is also known as quicksilver - symbolizing fluidity and speed]

Part 11: Design Methods Catalog

Mercury draws on a comprehensive toolkit of human-centered design methods:

Research Methods

Ethnographic Research

- Combines observation with interviews to understand what people do, not what they say
- Gives rich insight into daily lives, behaviors, and interactions
- Generates reusable insights
- Uncovers new knowledge about context and problems

User Testing

- Testing prototypes with actual users
- Observing how people interact with designs
- Identifying usability issues
- Validating assumptions

Expert Interviews

- Interviews with subject matter experts
- Document understanding
- Capture questions for further research

Stakeholder Interviews

- Establish project background, constraints, and goals
- Build rapport with decision-makers
- Ensure key stakeholders agree on goals

Contextual Inquiry

- Observing people in their natural environment
- Understanding context of use
- Identifying unspoken needs

Desktop Research

- Review of existing research
- Identifies what work has already been done
- Provides awareness of methodologies tried before

Landscape Review

- Understanding the broader ecosystem
- Identifying similar solutions
- Learning from others' experiences

Literature Review

- Academic and industry research
- Evidence-based insights
- Theoretical foundations

Survey/Quantitative Research

- Gathering data at scale
- Validating qualitative insights
- Sizing opportunities

Synthesis Methods

Affinity Mapping

- Organizing research insights
- Identifying patterns and themes
- Building shared understanding

Research Synthesis

- Ensuring stakeholder questions are answered
- Creating actionable recommendations
- Communicating insights effectively

Card Sorting

- Exploring relationships between content
- Deciding information structures
- Understanding mental models

Ideation Methods

Ideation Workshops

- Bringing stakeholders together
- Documenting ideas in response to problems
- Collaborative creativity

Design Sprints

- Time-boxed intensive workshops
- Rapid prototyping and testing
- Fast decision-making

Co-Design Workshops

- Citizens/users brought together
- Collaboratively define problems and solutions
- Inclusive design process

Prototyping Methods

Low-Fidelity Prototyping

- Quick, rough versions of design concepts
- Test core concepts early
- Minimize investment in wrong directions

High-Fidelity Prototyping

- Detailed, realistic prototypes
- Test usability and user experience
- Validate before implementation

Service Prototyping

- Mock-up of service delivery
- Test operational aspects
- Validate feasibility

Part 12: Output Artifacts

Mercury projects generate specific deliverables:

Research Outputs

Insights Report: Documented findings from research activities with actionable recommendations

Personas: Fictional archetypes representing user groups with similar needs and behaviors

Current State Journey Map: Visual representation of existing user experience showing touchpoints and pain points

User Scenarios: Narratives describing how users might interact with product or service

User Stories: Descriptions of user requirements for development backlog

Design Outputs

Design Concepts: Visual representations of potential solutions

Design Principles: Guiding statements for design decisions

Wireframes: Interactive prototypes demonstrating interface elements

Prototypes: Simulations/demos/mock-ups for testing ideas

Future State Journey Map: Vision for desired user experience

Service Blueprint: Journey map with operational processes mapped underneath

Strategic Outputs

Opportunities and Recommendations: Identified opportunities with actionable next steps

Value Proposition: Clear articulation of benefit and differentiation

Implementation Roadmap: Phased plan for delivering solution

Project Plan: Timeline, methodology, objectives, outcomes, team, and ways of working

Stakeholder Engagement Plan: Strategy for involving and communicating with stakeholders

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Part 13: Case Study - Continuous Cargo Risk Assessment (CCRA)

Background

The Australian Government faced a significant challenge with biosecurity at the border. Growth in trade volumes was putting pressure on Australia's biosecurity system, with the department

unable to provide sufficient officers to meet demand. The volume of inspections required was unfeasible, requiring a shift to real-time threat protection.

The Challenge

Industry Pain Points:

- Inspection delays causing significant costs ($500/day detention fees, 10-14 days typical)
- No visibility of biosecurity risk assessment status
- Outdated systems still requiring paper documentation
- Incomplete and inaccurate data not supporting biosecurity decision-making
- Lack of communication costing importers money
- Department couldn't meet inspection volumes

Department Challenges:

- Unfeasible to inspect every container
- Need to move to real-time risk assessment
- Legacy systems and processes
- Siloed information
- Resource constraints

Mercury Approach

Team Composition

A full Mercury team was assembled including:

- Department policy, operations, and technical representatives
- Industry participants (40+ importers and software providers)
- Data engineers
- Rules engine specialists
- UX/CX designers
- Technical developers
- Business analysts

The Process

Week 1-2: Mobilization and Planning

- Built champions panel of policy, operations, and technical team
- Established sandbox environment
- Positioned industry as co-design partners
- Set expectations for iterative prototyping

Week 2-4: Discovery

- Interviewed 60 people from 40 industry participants
- Conducted end-to-end journey mapping
- Analyzed 20+ AWE data reports
- Synthesized insights with champions
- Identified key pain points and opportunities

Week 4-12: Delivery

- Built multiple prototypes daily (initial phase)
- Showcased demos to champions as development progressed
- Integrated with importer systems
- Worked with multiple software providers
- Built dashboards for policy view
- Created operational insights tools
- Developed pre-arrival information capture
- Established continuous biosecurity risk assessment capability

Week 13: Approval

- Final showcase demonstrating value
- Proved the hypothesis
- Documented for production deployment

Key Mercury Practices Applied

Sandbox Environment:

- Allowed industry to be invited into the room
- Enabled rapid prototyping without security constraints
- Positioned expectations appropriately (don't expect perfection)
- Demonstrated value of co-design

Hyper-Agile Working:

- Brought importer, department, and technical governance into one team
- Daily iterations and showcases
- Rapid feedback loops
- Continuous validation

Showcasing as Proof of Value:

- Demonstrated prototype value continuously
- Showed pain points being addressed
- Provided estimated value for each team member
- Built confidence and buy-in

Customer Embedding:

- Integration built with importers, not for them
- Multiple software providers confirming what was working
- Real users testing real workflows
- Co-design throughout

What Was Delivered

Business Capabilities

1. **Biosecurity Dashboard:** End-to-end case load view
2. **Operational Insights:** Near real-time visibility of risk assessments
3. **Pre-arrival Information Capture:** Access to data and documents ahead of FID (Full Import Declaration)
4. **Continuous Biosecurity Risk Assessment:** Ongoing risk evaluation using rules engine
5. **Importer Experience:** Consignment risk reporting integrated into supply chain systems
6. **Staff Member Experience:** Data transparency for decision-making

Technical Capabilities

1. **Trust and Security Platform:** Identity, authentication, logging, monitoring
2. **DevSecOps:** CI-CD pipeline, code repository, test automation
3. **Sandpit Environment:** External integration, rapid solution design with industry
4. **Digital Experience Platform:** Business rules engine, BPM, ML/AI integration, B2G APIs
5. **Data Exchange Platform:** Event management and API management
6. **API with Industry Software Providers:** Real-time data exchange

User-Facing Solutions

- Industry software experience improvements
- Industry inspectors workflow tools
- Assessment through timeline visualization
- Operational dashboards
- Management dashboards

Outcomes and Benefits

For Importers:

- Real-time data offshore
- End-to-end visibility
- Reduced detention costs
- Faster clearance for compliant goods
- Embedded in supply chain management systems
- Make government "invisible" for compliant importers

For Department:

- Ability to dial up and down risk level settings
- Lower impost on safe pathways
- Immediate advice earlier to allow industry to respond
- Capability to manage growing volumes
- Better targeting of high-risk consignments
- Data-driven decision making

Proof of Hypothesis:
"This demonstrated that having that capability and put the rigor to have what is needed to deliver what was done. Understanding the ability to dial up and down risk level settings on inspections from the department meant lower impost on safe pathways and ensuring they have the ability. Also giving that immediate advice earlier to allow industry to respond. Deploying the PoC into production will have a significant change with landscape as it is."
— Carolyn McGill, Department Representative

Key Success Factors

1. **Co-design with Industry:** Building solutions with importers, not for them
2. **Sandbox Environment:** Safe space for experimentation and rapid prototyping
3. **Champions Panel:** Regular validation and ideation with key stakeholders
4. **Hyper-Agile Approach:** Daily iterations and showcases
5. **Mission Alignment:** Clear north star for all participants
6. **Customer Embedding:** Real users testing throughout
7. **Trans-disciplinary Team:** Policy, operations, technical, and customer together
8. **Proof of Value Showcasing:** Continuous demonstration of benefits

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Part 14: Implementing Mercury in Your Organization

When to Use Mercury

Mercury is most appropriate when:

Problem Characteristics

- **High ambiguity:** Requirements unclear, solution uncertain
- **High stakes:** Significant investment at risk
- **Complex ecosystem:** Multiple stakeholders, legacy systems, policy constraints
- **Urgent need:** Pressure to deliver quickly
- **Validation required:** Need to prove value before full investment

Organizational Context

- **Government environment:** Regulatory constraints, risk aversion, procurement complexity
- **Stuck programs:** Existing projects not delivering
- **Legacy challenges:** Old systems, siloed data, outdated processes
- **Customer disconnect:** Solutions not meeting user needs
- **Resource constraints:** Limited time, budget, or people

Success Indicators

- Executive sponsorship available
- Willingness to work differently
- Access to customers/users
- Access to data (or ability to get it)
- Appetite for rapid iteration
- Tolerance for early imperfect prototypes

Getting Started: The Launch Pad

Step 1: Executive Alignment

- Secure executive sponsor
- Build understanding of Mercury approach
- Set expectations for 13-week delivery
- Commit to principles (customer involvement, rapid prototyping, etc.)

Step 2: Problem Definition

- Articulate the challenge clearly
- Identify what's been tried before
- Define what success looks like
- Determine if Mercury is right fit

Step 3: Team Assembly

- Identify client representatives (business, technical, policy)
- Recruit Mercury team based on size/complexity
- Assign discipline leads
- Establish governance

Step 4: Mobilization Planning

- Schedule kick-off workshop
- Define initial scope boundaries
- Identify data access requirements
- Plan customer panel recruitment
- Set up sandbox environment

Step 5: Launch

- Conduct kick-off workshop
- Create placemat
- Begin discovery activities
- Start daily rituals
- Build first prototypes

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Building for Nobody

Problem: Team builds in isolation without showing work early
Solution: Daily showcases, customer panel involvement, early and often prototyping

Pitfall 2: Requirements Library

Problem: Extensive documentation that no one uses
Solution: Focus on working prototypes, lightweight documentation, continuous validation

Pitfall 3: Perfectionism

Problem: Waiting to show work until it's "finished"
Solution: Progress over perfection, embrace imperfect early versions, rapid iteration

Pitfall 4: Scope Creep

Problem: Expanding beyond 13-week deliverable
Solution: Placemat discipline, mission alignment, clear success criteria, park future ideas

Pitfall 5: Customer Theater

Problem: Consulting customers but not truly embedding them
Solution: Customer panel for life of project, hands-on testing, co-design sessions

Pitfall 6: Siloed Work

Problem: Disciplines working separately
Solution: Trans-disciplinary team, daily playbacks, shared workzone

Pitfall 7: Analysis Paralysis

Problem: Over-analyzing instead of building
Solution: Prototype early, test with real users, learn by doing

Pitfall 8: Forgetting the Brake

Problem: Moving fast without feedback mechanisms
Solution: Weekly value showcases, customer validation, champion team input

Scaling Mercury: The Mercury Factory

For organizations running multiple Mercury missions:

Community of Practice

- Regular sharing across Mercury teams
- Lessons learned sessions
- Method and tool sharing
- Skill development

Shared Services

- Customer panel management
- Research operations
- Sandboxing infrastructure
- DevSecOps pipelines
- Design system and patterns

Capability Building

- Mercury training programs
- Discipline lead development
- Government staff upskilling
- Certification pathways

Portfolio Management

- Prioritizing Mercury missions
- Resource allocation
- Dependency management
- Value tracking

Part 15: Differences from Other Methodologies

Mercury vs. Waterfall

Aspect	Waterfall	Mercury
Approach	Linear, sequential phases	Non-linear, iterative
Requirements	Detailed upfront	Emergent through discovery
Customer Involvement	Consulted at start and end	Embedded throughout
Risk Management	Planned and controlled	Embraced and navigated
Delivery	Big bang at end	Working prototypes from day 1
Timeline	Months to years	13 weeks guaranteed
Feedback	Late (after build)	Daily (lightspeed loops)
Value Proof	At implementation	Weekly showcases

Mercury vs. Scrum/Agile

Aspect	Scrum/Agile	Mercury
Team Structure	Cross-functional but often tech-focused	Trans-disciplinary: data, policy, tech, customer, business
Timeboxing	Sprints (1-4 weeks)	13-week mission (with internal iterations)
Customer Role	Product Owner proxy	Embedded customer panel
Scope	Evolving backlog	Mission-aligned placemat
Context	General software	Government-specific guardrails
Rituals	Stand-ups, retrospectives	Daily playbacks, value showcases, champion meetings
Output Focus	Shippable increment	Proof of value
Risk Approach	Technical debt management	Ambiguity attack, sandboxing

Mercury vs. Design Thinking

Aspect	Design Thinking	Mercury
Core Focus	User empathy and ideation	Mission alignment and delivery
Timeline	Flexible, often exploratory	Fixed 13 weeks, outcome guaranteed
Implementation	Often separate from design	Integrated: building from day 1
Team Composition	Designers with stakeholders	Full delivery team including tech and data
Deliverable	Concepts and prototypes	Working product in production-ready state
Government Fit	Requires adaptation	Purpose-built for government
Technical Integration	Added later	Embedded from start (data, rules, tech leads)

What Makes Mercury Unique

The Secret Sauce:

1. **Purpose-built for government:** Recognizes regulatory constraints, risk environment, procurement complexity
2. **Trans-disciplinary from day 1:** Data, tech, policy, rules, customer, business all together
3. **Guaranteed outcome:** 13-week commitment to usable product
4. **Guardrails for government:** Sandboxing, placemat, customer panel, champion team
5. **Speed with safety:** Rapid iteration within structured governance
6. **Value proving**: Weekly showcases demonstrating tangible benefit
7. **Mission alignment:** North star keeps all stakeholders aligned
8. **Lightspeed feedback:** Listen faster than you deliver
9. **Ambiguity embrace:** Attack uncertainty rather than avoid it
10. **From salvage experience:** Born from necessity, proven in crisis

Part 16: Mercury Value Proposition

For Government Departments

Rapid Delivery:

- Guaranteed usable outcome in 13 weeks
- Clear handover points between phases
- Tangible results quickly

Risk Mitigation:

- Sandbox environment for safe experimentation
- Continuous validation with customers
- Early detection of issues
- Ambiguity reduced systematically

Cost Efficiency:

- Avoid expensive failures
- Test before full investment
- Reusable insights and components
- Reduced support costs through better UX

Stakeholder Confidence:

- Weekly value showcases
- Transparent progress
- Evidence-based decisions
- Clear success criteria

Capability Building:

- Public servants embedded in team
- Learn by doing
- Modern practices adopted
- Organizational capability growth

For Citizens/Industry

Better Services:

- User-centered design
- Tested with real people
- Addresses actual pain points
- Intuitive and accessible

Faster Outcomes:

- Reduced wait times
- Streamlined processes
- Real-time information
- Proactive communication

Co-Design Benefits:

- Voice heard throughout
- Solutions fit real needs
- Ownership and buy-in
- Continuous improvement

For Technology Teams

Modern Practices:

- Cloud-first architecture
- API-first design
- DevSecOps pipelines
- Test-driven development

Integrated Approach:

- Not siloed from business
- Direct customer feedback
- Clear requirements through prototyping
- Continuous validation

Sustainable Pace:

- Structured but flexible

- Clear roles and responsibilities
- Support from discipline leads
- Learning environment

For Policy Teams

Evidence-Based:

- Real user insights
- Data-driven decisions
- Tested assumptions
- Validated hypotheses

Implementation-Ready:

- Technical feasibility proven
- Operational processes defined
- Change impacts understood
- Stakeholder buy-in secured

Agile Policy:

- Rapid testing of policy options
- Immediate feedback on implications
- Iterative refinement
- Future-proofed for change

Part 17: Success Measures

Outcome Metrics

Value Proven:

- Working product in hands of users
- Demonstrable benefits quantified
- Stakeholder validation secured
- Next steps clearly defined

13-Week Delivery:

- Met timeline commitment
- All phases completed
- Handover documentation complete
- Ready for next stage

Customer Validation:

- Positive user testing results
- Pain points addressed
- Workflows improved
- Adoption indicators strong

Technical Viability:

- Architecture sound
- Integration successful
- Performance acceptable
- Security validated

Business Alignment:

- Policy requirements met
- Operational feasibility confirmed
- Business case supported
- ROI indicated

Process Metrics

Team Performance:

- Daily playbacks completed
- Weekly showcases delivered
- Champion team engagement high
- Customer panel active

Iteration Velocity:

- Multiple prototypes in discovery
- Daily iterations in delivery
- Feedback incorporated rapidly
- Blockers resolved quickly

Stakeholder Engagement:

- Attendance at showcases
- Feedback quality
- Decision timeliness
- Satisfaction scores

Learning Metrics

Capability Transfer:

- Public servants skilled up
- Practices adopted
- Methods understood
- Tools mastered

Insights Generated:

- User research completed
- Data analysis delivered
- Recommendations documented
- Reusable artifacts created

Part 18: Conclusion

The Mercury Difference

Mercury is more than a methodology—it's a transformation in how government delivers digital services. Born from the necessity of salvaging failed projects, Mercury represents the distilled wisdom of what actually works in high-risk government environments.

The core insight: Speed and safety are not opposing forces. With the right guardrails, trans-disciplinary teams, and relentless focus on mission alignment, government can deliver validated outcomes at remarkable pace.

Key Takeaways

1. **13 weeks is achievable:** With disciplined approach and right team structure
2. **Customers must be embedded:** Not consulted—truly embedded throughout
3. **Show early and often:** Progress over perfection, value showcasing builds confidence
4. **Trans-disciplinary is essential:** Data, policy, tech, rules, customer, business—all together
5. **Ambiguity is opportunity:** Attack it with gusto rather than avoid it
6. **Mission alignment is the north star:** Keeps all stakeholders oriented
7. **Sandbox enables speed:** Safe environment for rapid experimentation
8. **Listen faster than you deliver:** Feedback loops as brake allow acceleration
9. **Government context matters:** Mercury purpose-built for regulatory environment
10. **Outcomes are guaranteed:** Not effort, not outputs—actual usable outcomes

Next Steps

To implement Mercury in your organization:

1. **Explore:** Review this manual, understand the principles
2. **Assess:** Identify a problem suitable for Mercury approach
3. **Engage:** Connect with Mercury practitioners
4. **Commit:** Secure executive sponsorship and resources
5. **Launch:** Assemble team, mobilize, deliver

Final Thought

> "Mercury allows the deployment of a tight team of 8-10 people with defined roles and clear handover points, giving executives tangible outcomes in 13-week increments. The zeitgeist has changed. Every project needs to build from day 1, work end to end from the data to the customer, and put the guardrails to allow outcomes. We must deliver teams that have precise mission focus."
> — Alex Kocz, Partner, Reason Group

Government has proved it can deliver with speed and agility. With Mercury, you no longer need a crisis to guarantee an increase in velocity at a sustainable pace.

Appendices

Appendix A: Design Plans Quick Reference

Mercury offers structured design plans organized under three categories:

Learn about a group or community:

- Option 1: Uncover existing knowledge (2-3 weeks, $20-25k)
- Option 2: Research focused user group (6-10 weeks, $60-80k)
- Option 3: Research diverse user groups (12-16 weeks, $150-200k)
- Option 4: Identify unmet community needs (12-24 weeks, $200-250k)

Develop strategic recommendations:

- Option 1: Identify opportunities and develop ideas (2-4 weeks, $20-25k)
- Option 2: Co-design solutions with users (8-10 weeks, $60-80k)
- Option 3: Design and test potential solution (8-10 weeks, $80-100k)
- Option 4: Design and test multiple solutions (12 weeks, $100-150k)
- Option 5: Strategic recommendations for existing product (12 weeks, $100-150k)

Prototype, test and iterate:

- Option 1: Document design basics (6 weeks, $40-80k)
- Option 2: Create validated low-fi prototypes (8-14 weeks, $100-150k)
- Option 3: Create high-fi designs ready for implementation (10-20 weeks, $150-250k)

Appendix B: Contact Information

For inquiries about implementing Mercury:

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Leadership Team:

- William Scheer, CEO & Founder
- Kevin Ho, COO & Principal
- Alex Kocz, Partner
- Aleksandar Vranesevic, Partner
- Mark Volpato, Partner

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Appendix C: Acknowledgments

This manual synthesizes content from:

- Mercury Playbook v1.0
- Mercury Manifesto (Work in Progress v2)
- Mercury Overview presentations (July 2022)
- Mercury team sizing documentation (September 2022)
- Government Innovation case studies (September 2022)
- Position descriptions for Mercury team roles

Developed in collaboration with government departments including:

- Department of Agriculture, Water and the Environment
- Services Australia
- Department of Employment, Skills and Education
- Department of Human Services

- Australian Bureau of Statistics

End of Manual

This comprehensive manual provides everything needed to understand and implement the Mercury Method for rapid government delivery. For the latest version and additional resources, visit reason.com.au